

THE CHASE IS ON
Indian women's team members at the national Kho Kho camp in Delhi

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SPORTS

Big Shout For Kho Kho

WITH SUBSTANTIAL INTERNATIONAL PARTICIPATION AT THE ONGOING KHO KHO WORLD CUP IN DELHI, THE GAME IS POISED TO GO GLOBAL

A decade back, when Nasreen Shaikh used to leave early in the morning for Kho Kho training, the community in her neighbourhood in Shakurpur, New Delhi, used to taunt the family. "Where is she going? Her parents don't care about her. How can she wear shorts?" Shaikh didn't take it to heart. "Girls anyway have to fight doubly hard to get their way. I wanted to show what a woman can do if she has support," says the 26-year-old. That came from her father, Mohammed Ghafoor, who used to save money to meet her dietary requirements. His efforts paid off, for Shaikh's exploits on both the *mitti* (mud) and mat are such that he is now better known as the father of Nasreen, the player who captained India through two Asian Championship titles and became only the second Kho Kho player to win the Arjuna award. These days, the family is excited to see her in action at the maiden Kho Kho World Cup which is being held in the capital from Jan. 13-19.

THE WORLD CUP WILL HAVE 21 TEAMS VYING FOR THE MEN'S TITLE; THE WOMEN'S BATTLE WILL SEE 19 TEAMS

The all-rounder will be one of the star players chasing and diving to ensure that host India wins. For Sudhanshu Mittal, president of the Kho Kho Federation of India, the World Cup is one way of following up on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's wish in his *Mann Ki Baat* where he spoke of taking Indian games global. While Team India, known for its strategy and skill, are firm favourites, the Cup will see teams from across continents competing. Apart from Asian contenders like Nepal, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka, there are teams—21 in men and 19 in women—from the US, England, South Korea, Poland and South Africa, to name a few.

Attacker Pratik Waikar, who has led Maharashtra to multiple national titles, feels the World Cup has the potential to be a "revolutionary event" in Indian sport. "Not many thought Kho Kho was worth taking up as a profession, for it didn't seem to have much international standing. Lots of kids leave the sport because of this or because